Markdown beside the PDF: one document, two readers

The markdown is the source, for helpers and editors. The PDF is rendered from it, for human eyes. We send both.

Walkthrough markdown beside PDF | Changed 2026-11-04 | For Partners who send us documents

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TL;DR

1. Every proposal, brief or paper the fleet sends has two forms.
2. The **markdown** (`README.md`) is the source, written for AI helpers and for anyone editing.
3. The **PDF** is rendered from it for human eyes.
4. We send both, and we ask partners to send both too.
5. A page you can point any helper at: *"Read my-template/walkthroughs/MARKDOWN-BESIDE-PDF.md."*

Why the markdown matters to a helper

- **A PDF is a picture of a page.** A helper has to extract the text back out of it, column by column, losing links, headings and tables along the way, and paying tokens for the extraction. The same words as markdown arrive as words: smaller, exact, with their structure intact.
- **Formatting is for people.** Unless a file *is* art (a render, a poster, a photograph), a helper does not care how the text looks. It cares what the text says and how it is organised.
- **Markdown is editable and diffable.** A reply can quote a line, a later revision can show what changed, and git keeps every version. A PDF can only be replaced.
- **It saves everyone tokens**, on both sides of a conversation, which keeps a helper's weekly budget for the work rather than for reading.

What we send

A folder per proposal, `NNN-short-name/README.md` , with its rendered `pdf/NNN-short-name.pdf` beside it. The PDF is the one a person opens; the markdown is the one a helper opens. Both say the same thing because one is made from the other (the template, the tones).

What we ask of a partner

When you share a document with us, please include the text form alongside the PDF, whichever is easiest:

If it was made with	Send
ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini or another assistant	the markdown or plain-text export of the same answer (most assistants offer "copy" or "export as Markdown"; the PDF was made from that text)
Google Docs or Word	**File** → **Download** → **Markdown** (Docs) or **Save as** → **Plain text** (Word), beside the PDF
A notes app or a chat message	the message itself is already text; paste it into a GitHub Issue or send it as is
A scan or a photograph of a page	the PDF or image is fine; say so, and we will transcribe it once and keep the transcription beside it

Nothing about the PDF changes. It is still the thing you read.

For a helper reading this on behalf of a partner

Prefer the `.md` next to any `.pdf` in a `proposals/` folder. If only a PDF arrived, read it once, write the transcription as `NNN-name/README.md` (or `source.md` beside the PDF when it is not ours), and say in the commit that it was transcribed. Never retype a document that already exists as text somewhere; ask for the text.

Suggest a change

Noticed something wrong, or a step that could be kinder? Open an issue or a pull request against `main`, changing this page. A person with the role reads it and merges with a merge commit, so your name stays on it. An AI helper may do all of that up to the merge. Not on GitHub? Tell any steward you know, or your helper, in your own words.

Written 2026-10-29 in the drasticstatic lab after a week of PDFs that began life as markdown. Related: `MANY-AI-TOOLS-ONE-TEAM.md`. Part of the walkthroughs.